

# **TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages**

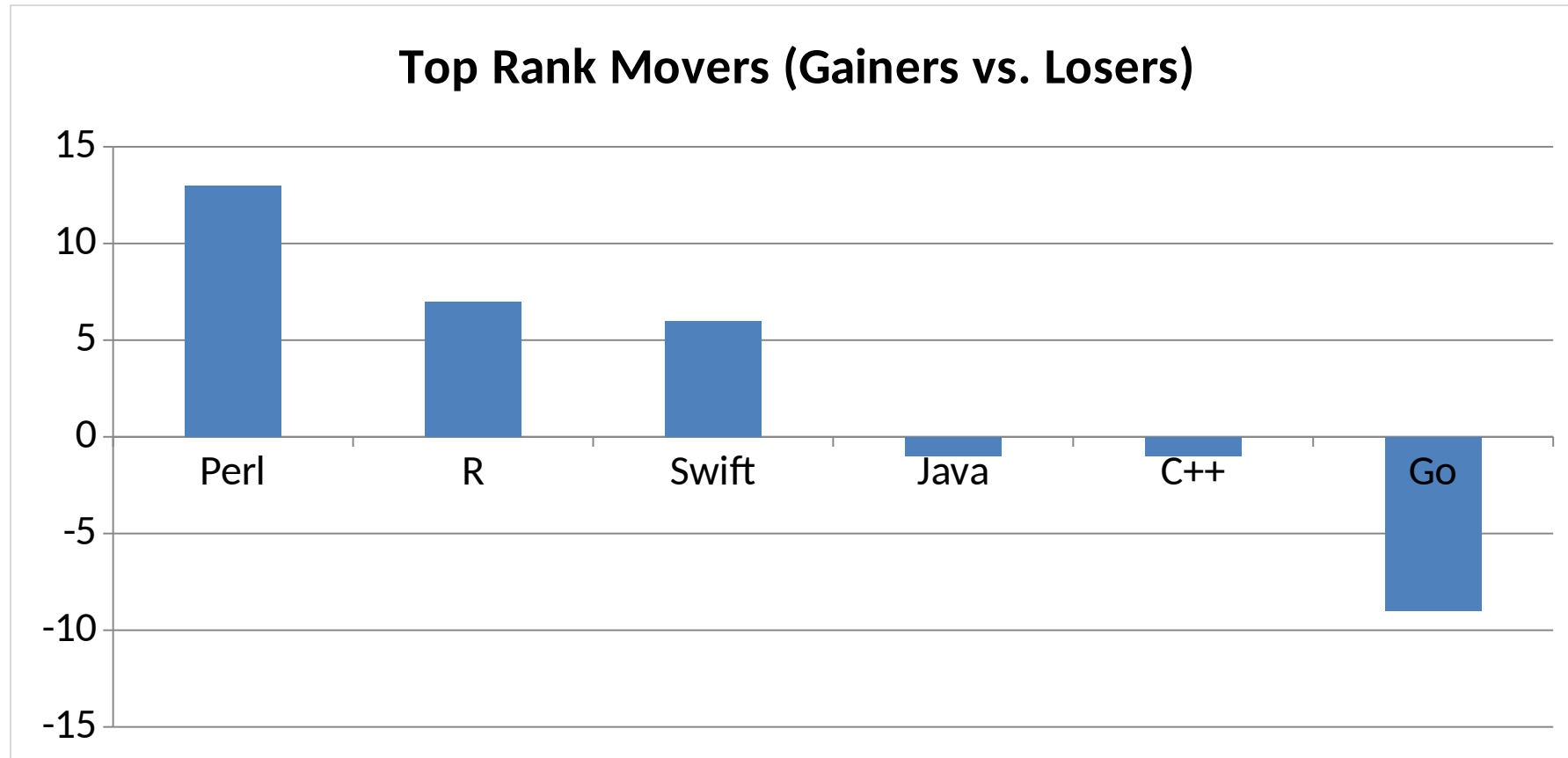
Python leads at 21.25% but posts the largest year-over-year decline among the top 5, while C surges to second and Go drops from 7th to 16th.

Target Audience: Software engineering leads and technology

# Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

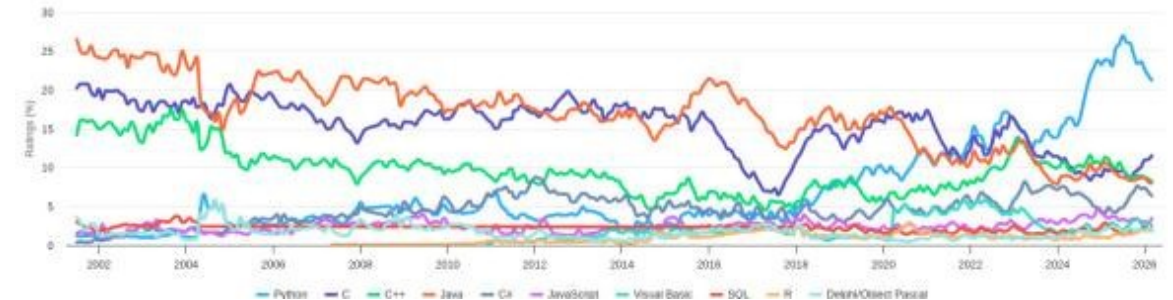
| Rank (Mar 2026) | Rank (Mar 2025) | Programming Language | Rating | YoY Change |
|-----------------|-----------------|----------------------|--------|------------|
| 1               | 1               | Python               | 21.25% | -2.59%     |
| 2               | 4               | C                    | 11.55% | +2.02%     |
| 3               | 2               | C++                  | 8.18%  | -2.90%     |
| 4               | 3               | Java                 | 7.99%  | -2.37%     |
| 5               | 5               | C#                   | 6.36%  | +1.49%     |
| 6               | 6               | JavaScript           | 3.45%  | -0.01%     |
| 7               | 9               | Visual Basic         | 2.50%  | -0.02%     |
| 8               | 8               | SQL                  | 2.00%  | -0.57%     |
| 9               | 16              | R                    | 1.88%  | +0.94%     |
| 10              | 10              | Delphi/Object Pascal | 1.80%  | -0.36%     |
| 11              | 24              | Perl                 | 1.75%  | +1.05%     |
| 12              | 12              | Scratch              | 1.63%  | -0.03%     |
| 13              | 11              | Fortran              | 1.45%  | -0.25%     |
| 14              | 14              | Rust                 | 1.31%  | +0.09%     |
| 15              | 15              | MATLAB               | 1.29%  | +0.31%     |
| 16              | 7               | Go                   | 1.29%  | -1.49%     |
| 17              | 17              | Assembly language    | 1.29%  | +0.42%     |
| 18              | 13              | PHP                  | 1.23%  | -0.25%     |
| 19              | 18              | Ada                  | 1.10%  | +0.25%     |
| 20              | 26              | Swift                | 1.04%  | +0.44%     |

# Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026



# From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

| Programming Language | 2026 | 2021 | 2016 | 2011 | 2006 | 2001 | 1996 | 1991 | 1986 |
|----------------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|
| Python               | 1    | 3    | 5    | 7    | 8    | 26   | 17   | -    | -    |
| C                    | 2    | 1    | 2    | 2    | 2    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 1    |
| C++                  | 3    | 4    | 3    | 3    | 3    | 2    | 2    | 2    | 9    |
| Java                 | 4    | 2    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 3    | 31   | -    | -    |
| C#                   | 5    | 5    | 4    | 5    | 7    | 11   | -    | -    | -    |
| JavaScript           | 6    | 7    | 8    | 10   | 10   | 8    | 33   | -    | -    |
| Visual Basic         | 7    | 6    | 11   | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    |
| Delphi/Object Pascal | 8    | 185  | 12   | 12   | 9    | -    | -    | -    | -    |
| SQL                  | 9    | 10   | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    |
| Go                   | 10   | 11   | 60   | 16   | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    |
| Ada                  | 14   | 36   | 25   | 22   | 16   | 18   | 6    | 10   | 3    |
| Lisp                 | 26   | 34   | 26   | 13   | 14   | 19   | 8    | 4    | 2    |
| (Visual) Basic       | -    | -    | -    | 6    | 6    | 4    | 3    | 3    | 4    |



rose from unranked to dominant, Java peaked and declined, and C has remained in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.

# Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

| Year | Winner       |
|------|--------------|
| 2025 | C#           |
| 2024 | Python       |
| 2023 | C#           |
| 2022 | C++          |
| 2021 | Python       |
| 2020 | Python       |
| 2019 | C            |
| 2018 | Python       |
| 2017 | C            |
| 2016 | Go           |
| 2015 | Java         |
| 2014 | JavaScript   |
| 2013 | Transact-SQL |
| 2012 | Objective-C  |
| 2011 | Objective-C  |
| 2010 | Python       |
| 2009 | Go           |
| 2008 | C            |
| 2007 | Python       |
| 2006 | Ruby         |
| 2005 | Java         |
| 2004 | PHP          |
| 2003 | C++          |

Python has won the award six times total (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024).

C# won twice recently (2023, 2025), reflecting its continuous growth in the .NET ecosystem.

Go's 2016 win preceded its current sharp decline to 16th place in 2026.

Note: The 2017 winner is not available in the source data.

# The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

- Python's Dominance vs. Trajectory: Still leads by a wide margin (21.25%), but posted the largest YoY decline among the top 5 (-2.59%).
- C's Resurgence: Gained +2.02 points, reclaiming the #2 spot and showing strong momentum.
- Legacy Revival: Perl (+13 spots), R (+7 spots), and Fortran remain highly relevant in scientific, data, and infrastructure contexts.
- Go's Sharp Fall: Dropped 9 spots (7th to 16th),